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Subject: CAN A.I. HAVE TASTE?
Date: August 27, 2025 at 10:03 AM
To: mlopezrey@me.com



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CAN A.I. HAVE TASTE?

And, every A.I. technology my studio uses to transform our creative process

🔒 AUG 27



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Wearstlerworld,

Honestly, A.I. comes up for me in *most* conversations – a lot of people I talk to feel daunted by it – either overwhelmed by the flood of tools or afraid it will strip the humanity from their work.

But, I think they always come around. Or at least they are *curious*.

It's transformed my creative practice for the better. **Every day we integrate new and better A.I. tools into our process, and our studio is becoming *more human, not less*.**

It's sped up our industrial design process, it's made our presentations to clients more dynamic and convincing, it's made project teams crazy efficient and has all but eliminated miscommunications. All in the service of the studio spending time on what matters: adding the layer of human emotion, understanding of materiality, and in giving us back the time to experience the world and its beauty in order to direct, edit, curate, and compose amazing design work.

Now I want to show you how we're doing it: play-by-play, across departments. The exact tools we use, how they fit into our process, and where you can start.

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A.I. IS THE NEW LUXURY

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LITIES. SPACES DEFINED BY SCULPTURAL FURNISHINGS AND STRUCTURAL

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-ORGANIC ABSTRACTIONS, MASSIVE BLOCKS, ARCHES, VOIDS, CIR
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RCHITECTURAL SENSIBILITIES. SPACES DEFINED BY SCULPTURAL



MODEL BEHAVIOR: WHY MY A.I. WON'T BE YOUR A.I.

I've been completely bullish on A.I. from the start. (And, Brad is too - in his work.)

My first step was to learn as much as I could (some of my resources below!) and also figure out who in my studio would be 'early adopters', a few people that shared my desire to experiment. That was the spark, and we could all see almost immediately how transformative it could be.

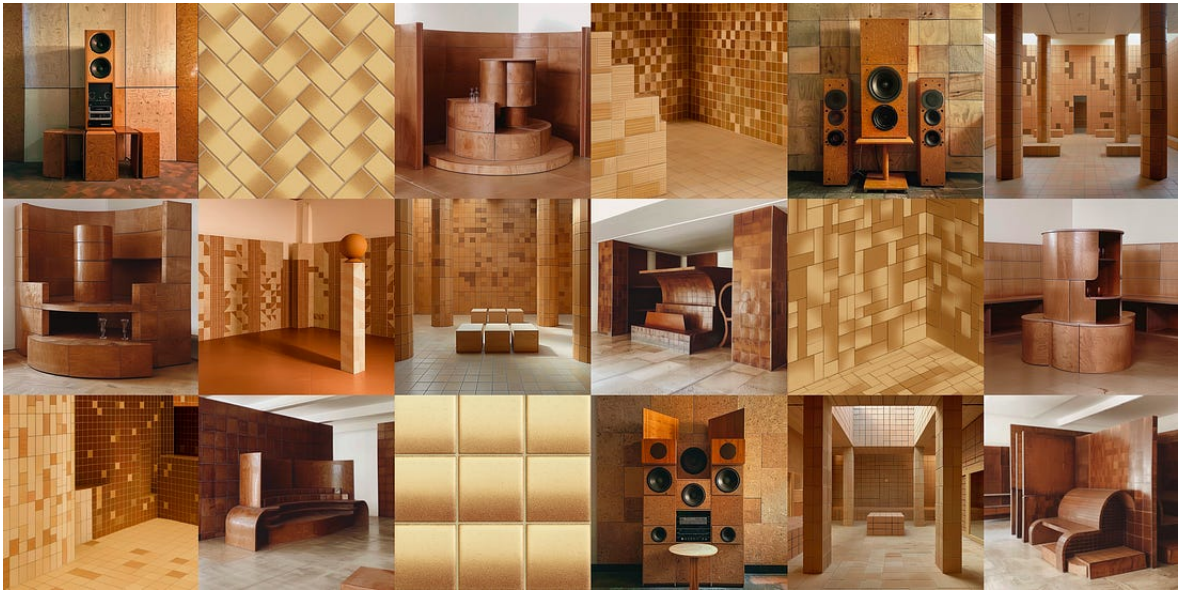
There's always something new we're building into our work, that will help make it more *our own*. My latest obsession? Vibe-coding - a term coined by Andrej Karpathy, former A.I. director at Tesla and co-founder of OpenAI.

For us, vibe-coding means creating an A.I. space that preserves the essence of "Kelly Wearstler." It acts like our own private model: surfacing historic references, visual inspiration, and clear creative direction that keeps the entire team aligned. And it's always evolving: every trip we take, every discovery we make, every new idea feeds it, sharpening its sense of our precise design DNA.

Here's the point: our A.I. won't be your A.I.

A.I. is not about flattening creativity or creating a homogenous output - it has the power to do the exact opposite.

(More on our vibe-coding process in a future post!)



Concept studies for the creative direction of a photo shoot,
for a new tile collection (using Midjourney, ChatGPT, and
Photoshop AI)

EVERY STEP OF THE WAY

Of course, there will be cycles to this new tech: times it makes big leaps, and others when (sort of like now) it's struggling to jump a hurdle. But, even as it is today, A.I. supports us in all the studio's work – and not just a little, but *a lot*. And what's exciting is the horizon: the potential and possibilities. Getting on board now is the best preparation for the next seismic advances.

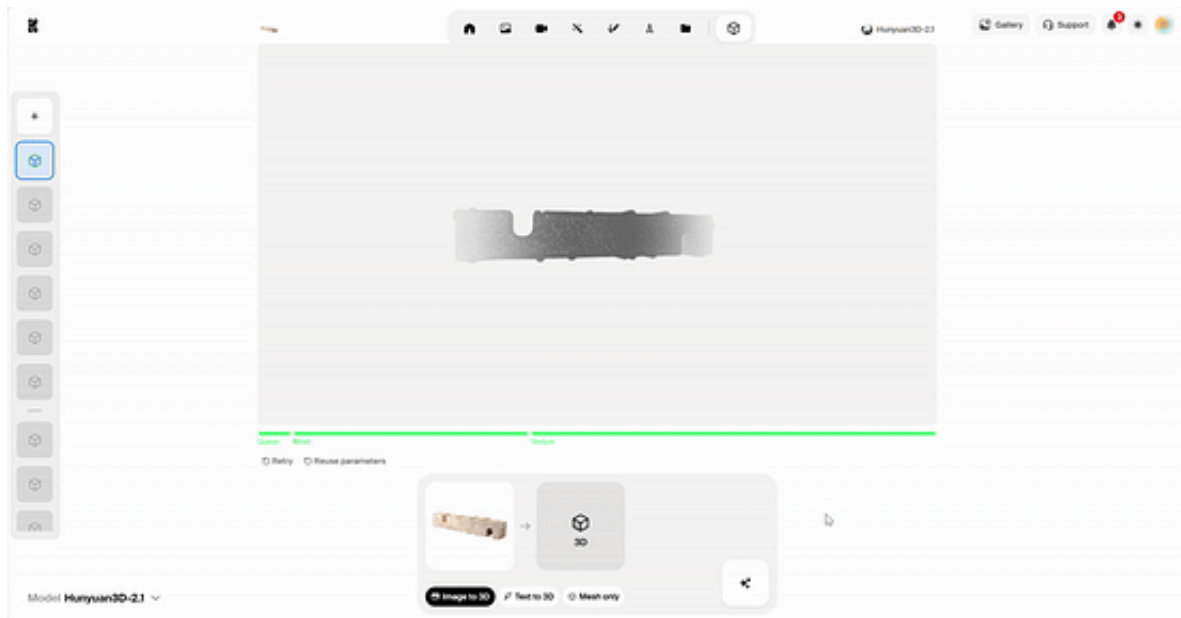
And here's how it's working across the process:

MAKING WORK

Let's start with how we're making work. What's happening in our industrial design department is a great example: what once took days of manual modeling now takes minutes, even turning 2D drawings into 3D in seconds (using **Krea**). What does that allow us to do? Try out so many more ideas, iterating and experimenting endlessly until we get to where we want to be.



We took our Hume bench, and used that as the design language for a series of other furniture studies through **Midjourney**.



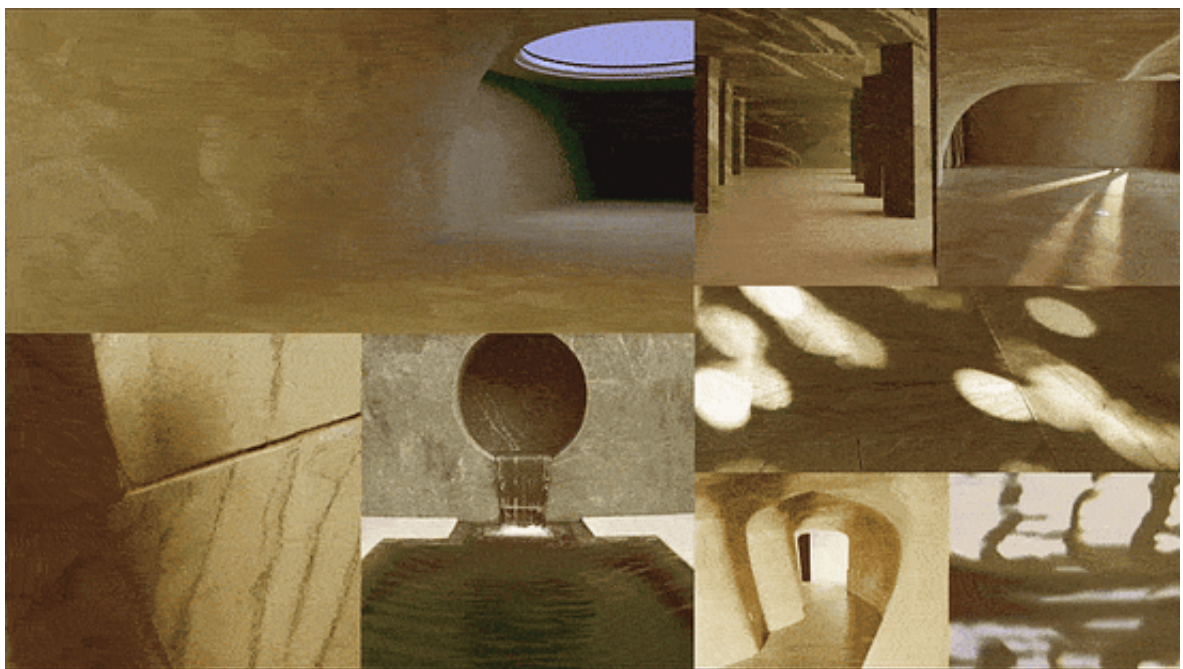
Converting 2D images to 3D using **Krea**.

SHOWING WORK

Video has completely transformed our client presentations. It's immediate, convincing, and eliminates the need to "paint a picture" with words – it's already there to see.

already there to see.

We first tested **Sora** eight months ago as beta users with OpenAI, and it's been incredible watching a new wave of tools emerge. Now, we use **Midjourney**, **Veo 3**, and **Runway** to turn still images into GIFs and short videos – visuals that appear on nearly every slide actually. As part of our Lake Tahoe project, the transformation of Cal Neva (which is a super expansive and complex project), we used **Midjourney** to create a simple fly-through of new world-class spa – here is a first iteration of that:



For the presentation, we put together an incredible 2-minute short film, that was really compelling to the developers and owners of Cal Neva – and that was using a combination of **Sora**, **Midjourney**, and **Runway**, and then edited using **Adobe After Effects**.

REFINING WORK

If first we use **Krea** and **Midjourney** for concept and exploration (it's great to show the unexpected, the wide-open possibilities) then we bring the work into **ChatGPT** to refine. Chat lets us keep the core design while

swapping out variables: materials, textures, even entire contexts. Swapping a kitchen design through wood, polished metal, or stone? We're doing it in seconds, not hours.

And, you can't forget: Adobe's A.I. tools take it further, making it so much easier in **Photoshop** to add some super precise finishing touches (Chat isn't *quite* there yet).



Studies on volume and materiality, using **Midjourney** and **ChatGPT**.

COLLABORATING WITH CLIENTS AND

ARTISTS

We work on projects all over the world. For two in Europe (in France and Sweden) we've been leaning on **Zoom**'s built-in A.I. translation.

Not everyone on site speaks English, from contractors to craftspeople, and we always want to collaborate closely with local talent (for all sorts of reasons). Real-time subtitles are pretty astounding, and they get us most of the way there – enough to keep the work flowing, and the communication is seamless.

COLLABORATING AS A TEAM

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THE MAGIC WASN'T
ABOUT SPEED. THE REAL
WOW MOMENT WAS WHEN
AI PUSHED US INTO
IDEAS WE COULDN'T
HAVE IMAGINED ALONE
— THAT'S WHERE THE
SPARK OF CREATIVITY
HAPPENED.

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Last but not least, A.I. is also woven into how we work as a team. Our legal, financial, and operations teams all use it, and it's become a cornerstone of major, multi-dimensional projects – like Cal Neva, and in Stockholm.

For those, we've **trained GPTs** on every presentation, concept, and piece of correspondence – a closed system that searches only within the project. When someone new joins, they don't have to chase down answers. The chat can tell them instantly: "What was the feedback on the first concept presentation?"

It cuts miscommunication and adds speed.

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There are no unicorns (yet) in A.I., no silver bullets.

Like so many other tools, you have to learn not just the tool, but what it's best used for – and how to combine them. Here's our current lineup:

WHAT TO USE

RESEARCH
AND

VIDEO,
ANIMATION

KNOWLEDGE

CHAT GPT

Build custom GPTs, conduct project research, interpret code and technical requirements, provide software guidance

COMET BY PERPLEXITY

Conduct deep research, organize calendars and schedules, create centralized knowledge hubs with Spaces

NOTION

Reference the studio's knowledge base, summarize meeting notes and documents

WRITING, COMMUNICATION, ORGANIZATION

CHAT GPT

Proofread complex emails, create presentation templates, manage tasks and schedules

OTTER + READ

Transcribe meeting notes, follow up on action items, convert voice into tasks

NOTION

Draft project documents, manage brainstorm tasks

CLAUDE

Research, simple writing tasks

VISUAL DESIGN AND IMAGE GENERATION

MIDJOURNEY

Generate product design images, convert still images into video

KREA

Generate photorealistic images from text or sketches, convert still images into video, generate 3D models

FIGMA AI

Generate templates and images, convert images to high resolution

ADOBE PHOTOSHOP AI

Auto-generate backgrounds, apply generative fills, use auto-fillers

CHAT GPT

Generate product design images

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ANIMATION, MOTION

RUNWAY

Create mood board animations

KREA, MIDJOURNEY

Convert still images into video

GOOGLE PRO TOOLS

Generate video from prompts

VOICE, AUDIO

CLAUDE + ELEVEN LABS

Generate voices

OTTER + READ

Transcribe voice to text, convert voice to tasks

SEARCH, A.I. ASSISTANCE

GOOGLE PRO TOOLS

{ AI MODE }

Advanced search

CHAT GPT

Knowledge sharing, code interpretation, research, and task management

TECHNICAL AND 3D DESIGN

KREA

Generate 3D models

CHAT GPT

Convert plans and elevations into 3D views

MIDJOURNEY

Convert them into 3D walk-throughs, often from architectural studies produced using Enscape

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OUR A.I. IS OUR DNA

We never build mood boards from other studios' current projects. Of course, we pay attention (we love design!), but we don't want our work to chase a "moment." Our goal is always to reflect our clients and create something timeless.

Instead, our inspirations come from everywhere: past projects across all disciplines (architecture, industrial, graphic), historic imagery, art, music, playlists, materials, scents, poetry, and always the context of the project itself.

Those are the ingredients we're feeding into our A.I. models. The model becomes a living archive of our creative world, drawing from what we've built, what we've experienced, and what moves us to generate ideas that still feel distinctly *ours*.

I shared more about this process of mood boarding and conceptual design in **the second newsletter about the rebuilding of our Malibu home**. (The third, coming soon, dives into how we're working with our architects.)





PROMPT
ARCHITECTURAL

A REFINED SPA
ENVIRONMENT IS
CLAD IN MARBLE WITH
INTRICATE VEINING
PATTERNS AND OLD
AND BEAUTIFUL
GIVING
LUXURY
SERENE AMBIANCE.
THE CEILING
FEATURES A LARGE



OCULUS, CREATING A CENTRAL WATERFALL

TEAM BUILDING: WHY A.I. IS GROWING OUR STUDIO

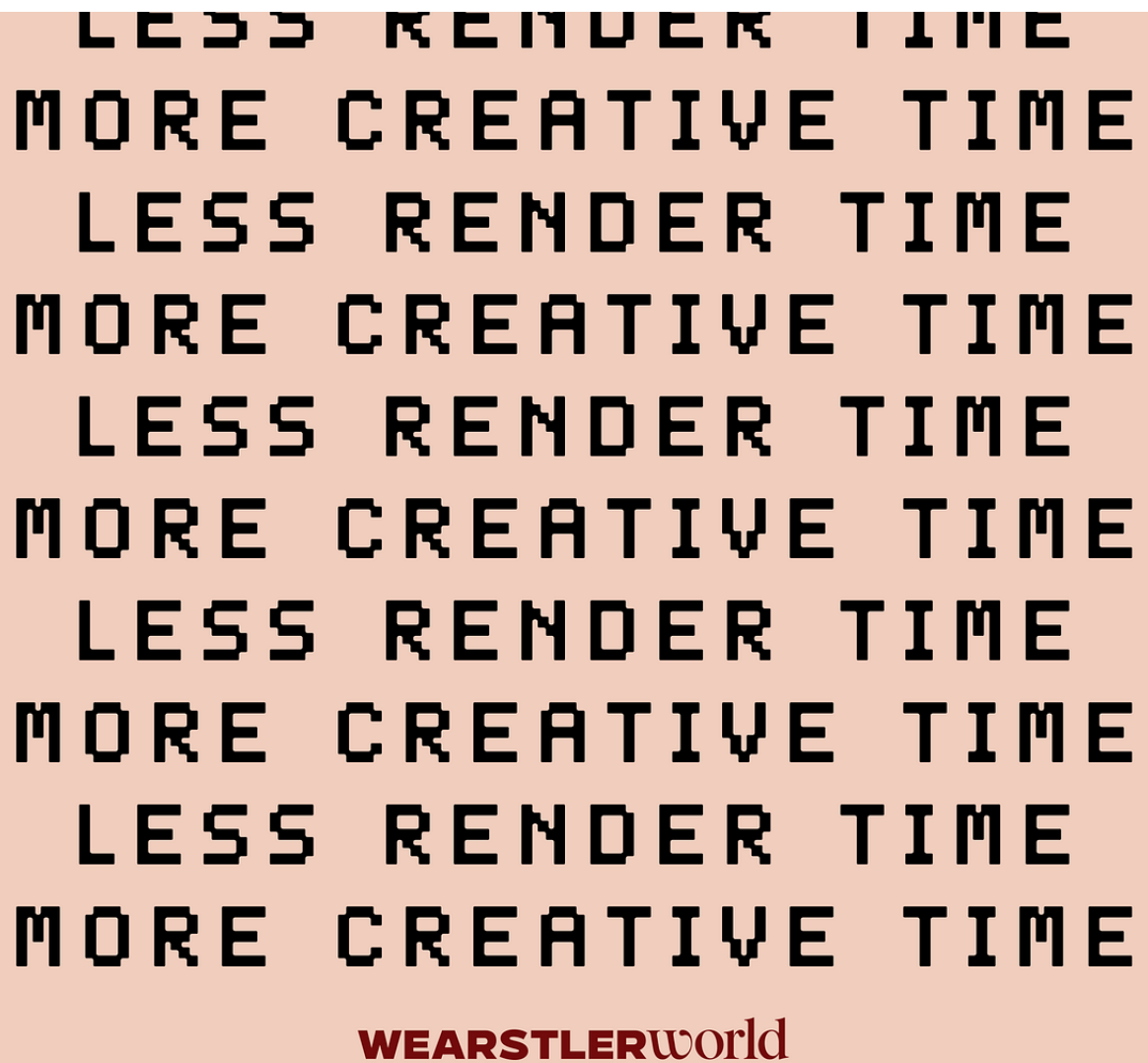
I think about it like this: technology has always pushed creativity forward. A.I. is just the latest – though it's the most revolutionary we've seen in a long time. For creative businesses, it's not about replacing screen time with more screen time; it's about freeing us from some of the manual work so we can spend more time exploring, experimenting, and actually creating.

A.I. is opening us up to so much new work, and supporting the talented people I work with across the board. We wouldn't be where we are today, as a studio, without A.I. We're bigger and more productive than ever.

And you know what: **we're hiring** (humans).

But, I'm also very proud of the environment we're creating for another reason: A.I. is our future, and everyone at the studio is going to be ready for it – to have a role in the new creative landscape. And that's because we're not resisting the change, we're leading it.

LESS RENDER TIME
MORE CREATIVE TIME
LESS RENDER TIME



HOW TO START

The thing to know is that A.I. tools are just as powerful for a studio of two as they are for a studio of 200.

Some are already part of your daily life – even if you might not notice it (think Google searches). Others are right under your nose: I’ve been super impressed with the new capabilities packed into the iPhone – I don’t think a lot of people know the power of what they’ve got in their pockets!

.....

We've been using A.I. for three years. It's been a full embrace, but you still need to be thoughtful about which tools you combine. (We're still fine-tuning the recipe!) So, **you need to be intentional**.

For most people, the easiest entry point is ChatGPT and Claude, the text-to-text and text-to-image tools. They've been incredible for experimentation and, for us, have even replaced Google as a first stop for research.

But other, familiar software is now inseparable from A.I., too: Airtable, Notion, Figma – all with integrations that do more than ever before.

Here is sort of what our path was, and I think it's great to copy:

HOW TO USE

01 START WITH TEXT-BASED TOOLS

Begin with accessible platforms like **ChatGPT** or **Claude**. Use them for brainstorming, writing prompts, drafting ideas, and managing tasks. They can also act as co-pilots for communication – helping refine emails, documents, and presentations.

02 BRING AI INTO YOUR WORKFLOW TOOLS

Adopt AI features within the software you already use: **Adobe Creative Suite, Figma, Notion, Airtable, Canva, or Adobe Express**. Designers especially benefit from Figma's templates, while everyday users can take advantage of built-in AI across phones and productivity apps.

03 EXPERIMENT WITH VISUAL GENERATION

Test creative tools like **MidJourney**, **ChatGPT** image generation, **Sora**, or

Google Veo 3 to produce early concepts, mood boards, or inspiration images. Start small—one project or visual prompt at a time—and see how outputs respond to your direction.

04 TRAIN YOUR OWN MINI-MODEL

Curate your past work – images, videos, text prompts – and use it to “tune” **AI** toward your creative style. Begin with a single project, feeding in historical references and inspiration so the system reflects your personal **design DNA**.

05 USE AI AS SUPPORT, NOT REPLACEMENT

Define what should be machine-generated versus hand-crafted. **AI** can accelerate iterations and surface new directions, but final decisions – curation, material selection, execution – should remain human-led

06 ITERATE AND REFINE

Treat **AI** as an ongoing experiment. Note what works, discard what doesn't, and gradually expand its role in your process as you build confidence and clarity.

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AND, HERE IS WHO TO FOLLOW

Here's who we're paying attention to to keep up on the latest – but, know that Wearstlerworld is going to be returning to the subject of A.I. every six or eight weeks with updates from our studio, and my life.

But to get you up to speed:

This Week in Startups

You hear about all the innovation, get to know what's coming, and what the new business strategies are before things even really hit the market. Hosted by my friend, Jason Calacanis.



This Week in Startups

Jason Calacanis

Podcast

And two more, great for the latest in AI news:

The AI Daily Brief:



The AI Daily Brief (Formerly The AI Breakdown): Artificial Intelligence News and Analysis

Nathaniel Whitemore

Podcast

Everyday AI:



EP 597: Do 95% of AI Pilots Fail? Why You Should Ignore MIT's Viral New AI "Study"

Everyday AI

Episode

@CHATGPTJUNKIE and @CHATGPTTRICKS

IG/Threads accounts that give you ideas and tips on how to formulate your prompts, and manipulate the A.I. to give you exactly what you need.

BIG TECH CONFERENCES

Every major tech company now will talk about A.I., and definitely always in an annual conference. Things like GOOGLE IO and Config by Figma.

IN THE END: IT'S ALL IN THE EXECUTION



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TASTE
IS THE
FILTER



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Can A.I. do your creative work for you?

Shortcuts have always existed, but pushing creativity forward takes drive. Those who use A.I. as a substitute for their own creativity won't be the ones moving design, fashion, gaming, or film forward.

It all comes down to execution. A.I. can't do the magic for you. You need an intimate understanding of scale, material, color, light, and composition (... and history!). You have to take the ideas A.I. generates and be their best editor and curator.

Innovation doesn't come from simply *using* A.I. – it comes from engaging with it thoughtfully. That engagement requires critical thinking, and a point of view – both deeply human skills.

So, can A.I. have taste? Only if you do.

Let me know what A.I. questions you have – in any dimension of life! I'm excited to bring you into this fast-moving world – it will transform you!

XO





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COMMENT



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